The BJP also tried to strike a secret deal with the Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS) leader Raj Thackeray. In the 2009 elections, Raj's presence had cost the BJP–Sena alliance around eight seats because he split their vote. Gadkari was assigned the task of wooing Raj. The meeting was fixed in a five-star hotel in central Mumbai. 'The only problem was that as we entered the hotel lift, a journalist saw us. The meeting was no longer secret,' Raj told me later. The Shiv Sena, which was engaged in a family war with the MNS, wouldn't allow the deal to go through. But an agreement was still reached—Raj would at least support the idea of Modi as prime minister.

Raj, unlike his cousin, the very earnest-looking Udhav, was charismatic. He had modelled himself on his uncle, Shiv Sena founder Bal Thackeray. Like Balasaheb, Raj enjoyed the good things of life—beer, cigars and an enviable DVD library of old movies; he also had an impressively large collection of aftershaves. The Great Dane which guarded his residence seemed to trumpet his tough style. We had common friends, most notably Sachin Tendulkar. Raj loved play-acting before the camera. He would be warm and friendly in conversation, but the moment the camera was switched on, he would become openly hostile. In an interview we did during the elections, he kept asking me to 'keep quiet', 'sit back' and 'behave yourself'. The moment the interview was over, he laughed, 'Arre, Rajdeep, did you like my style, *maza aya*? I am sure you will get huge TRPs for this interview!' It was, as they would say in Mumbai, 'full-on drama'.

That every seat mattered for the BJP was confirmed when the party decided to allow its former Karnataka chief minister B.S. Yeddyurappa to return to the fold. For months, Yeddyurappa, who had been tangled in corruption charges, had been kept waiting. Advani was against allowing him back into the BJP. Modi had no such compunctions. 'If Yeddyurappa can get us even one or two extra seats in Karnataka, it's worth it,' was the verdict. He was, after all, still the party's most powerful Lingayat face and mass leader.

Yeddyurappa, his forehead perpetually adorned with sandalwood and fingers crowded with rings, like so many Indian politicians, is a great